

Word family: **associate / associates / associated / associating / association / associative**

Base word: associate

Past tense: associated

Past participle: associated

-ing form: associating

Related forms: association, associative

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / noun (名詞) / adjective (形容詞 , 部分正式職銜 / 結構中)

Your sentence:

> “We are not as close as we used to be, because life has taken us in different directions, but I still
associate him with some of the happiest and simplest years of my life.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **associate A with B** means to **connect two people, things, ideas, or memories in your mind so that one makes you think of the other**.

繁體中文： **在思想或記憶中把兩個人、事物、概念或經歷聯繫起來；一想到其中一個便自然聯想到另一個**

中文翻譯：

> “...I still **associate him with** some of the happiest and simplest years of my life.”

「.....但我仍然會把他**和我人生中最快樂、最單純的那幾年聯繫在一起**。」

Here:

associate Ryan with happy childhood years = 一想到 Ryan , 就會聯想到那些快樂的童年歲月

1. **associate A with B = connect mentally (聯想) — 把.....與.....聯繫起來；聯想到**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: To form a mental connection between two people, things, ideas, experiences, or qualities.

Practice 1 — Original

> “I still **associate him with** some of the happiest years of my life.”

「我仍然把他**和我人生中最快樂的那些歲月聯繫在一起**。」

Practice 2

> “Many people **associate** that song **with** summer.”

「很多人會把那首歌**和夏天聯想在一起**。」

Practice 3

> “I always **associate** this smell **with** my childhood.”

「我總會把這種氣味**和童年聯繫起來**。」

****associate A with B = 在腦中建立 A 和 B 之間的聯繫，使其中一個令人想到另一個****

Common:

- * associate a person with a memory
- * associate a smell with a place
- * associate a colour with an emotion
- * associate something with childhood

2. ****associate = connect two things because they are related (關聯) — 把.....聯繫；認為.....有關****

****Associate**** can also mean to regard two things as being connected, related, or linked in reality, not merely in personal memory.

Practice 4

> “Researchers have **associated** poor sleep with lower concentration.”

「研究人員把睡眠不足**與**較低的專注力**聯繫起來**。」

Practice 5

> “The condition is often **associated with** stress.”

「這種情況常常**與壓力有關**。」

****associate A with B = 認為 A 和 B 之間存在某種關係、連結或共同出現的情況****

This is closely related to Meaning 1, but the emphasis is more on an ****objective or perceived relationship**** than a personal mental association.

For strict counting, I would merge these under one broad **connect/link** concept, while keeping both learner-facing uses explicit.

3. **associate with someone** = spend time / mix socially (交往) — 與.....來往；交往

Meaning: To spend time with someone socially or have regular contact with them.

Practice 6

> “He rarely **associates with** people from work outside office hours.”

「他很少在辦公時間以外**和同事來往**。」

Practice 7

> “She began to **associate with** a new group of friends.”

「她開始**和一群新朋友交往**。」

associate with someone = 與某人有社交往來、經常接觸或一起活動

This is a genuinely different verb meaning from mental association.

It can sound slightly formal compared with:

> spend time with

> hang out with

4. **associate** = be connected with an organization/activity (聯繫 / 參與) — 與.....有關；參與

Someone can be **associated with** an organization, institution, project, movement, or activity.

Practice 8

> “She has been **associated with** the organization for many years.”

「她多年來一直**與該機構有關 / 參與該機構工作**。」

Practice 9

> “Several researchers were ****associated with**** the project.”

「有幾名研究人員****參與 / 與這個項目有關****。」

****be associated with = 與某個機構、活動或項目有正式或實際聯繫****

This is a passive/adjectival extension of the broader ****connection**** meaning.

For core counting, I would merge it into the broad connect/link sense.

5. ****associate = colleague / business partner (名詞) — 同事 ; 合作夥伴 ; 同僚****

As a noun, ****associate**** can mean a person you work with, do business with, or have a professional connection to.

Practice 10

> “He introduced me to one of his business ****associates****.”

「他把我介紹給其中一位商業****夥伴 / 同業人士****。」

Practice 11

> “Several of her former ****associates**** attended the event.”

「她幾位以前的****同事 / 合作夥伴****出席了活動。」

****an associate = 與某人工作、商業或專業關係的人****

This is a distinct noun meaning.

6. ****associate = lower-ranking/member-level position or title (職位) — 副職 ; 初級 / 中階職位****

In job titles, ****associate**** can indicate a particular professional rank or level.

Examples include:

- * associate professor
- * associate director
- * sales associate
- * research associate

Practice 12

> “She works as a research **associate**.”

「她是一名研究**助理 / 研究員級職員**。」

Practice 13

> “He was promoted to **associate director**.”

「他獲晉升為**副總監**。」

****associate + job title = 某些機構中表示副職、較初級或特定職級的正式職稱****

The exact rank varies by organization, so the Chinese translation must depend on context.

This is best treated as a ****title/role extension****, not as a broad semantic meaning to overgeneralize.

7. ****associate = secondary/member status (形容詞) — 準會員的 ; 副級的 ; 相關的****

As an adjective, ****associate**** can describe someone or something connected with an organization but not necessarily holding full or primary status.

Practice 14

> “He became an ****associate member**** of the society.”

「他成為該學會的****準會員 / 附屬會員****。」

Practice 15

> “She is an ****associate editor**** of the journal.”

「她是該期刊的****副編輯 / 助理編輯****。」

****associate + role/status = 與某組織有正式聯繫，但職級、地位或會員身分可能不是最高 / 完整級別****

Again, exact institutional meaning varies, so I would treat this mainly as a title-pattern extension.

Related form: **associated**

Associated commonly means connected or linked with something.

Practice 16

> “The risks **associated with** the activity are low.”

「與這項活動**相關**的**風險**很低。」

Practice 17

> “The festival and its **associated** events attract many visitors.”

「這個節日及其**相關活動**吸引很多遊客。」

associated = 與某人、某事物或某活動有關聯的

Related form: **association**

Association has several important meanings.

association = connection between ideas/things (聯繫) — 聯想 ; 關聯

Practice 18

> “The smell has a strong **association** with childhood memories.”

「這種氣味和童年記憶有很強的**聯想 / 關聯**。」

association = 兩個人、事物、概念或經歷之間的心理或實際聯繫

association = organization/group (協會) — 協會 ; 團體

Practice 19

> “She belongs to a professional **association**.”

「她是一個專業**協會**的會員。」

Practice 20

> “The local residents’ **association** held a meeting.”

「本地居民**協會**舉行了會議。」

association = 因共同職業、興趣、目的或身分而組成的正式團體

This is genuinely distinct from the abstract “connection” meaning.

Related form: **associative**

Associative is more academic/technical.

It means involving association or the linking of ideas.

Practice 21

> “The exercise encourages **associative** thinking.”

「這項練習鼓勵**聯想式思考**。」

associative = 與聯想、事物之間的連結或聯結思維有關的

This is useful but lower priority than **association**.

Important distinction: **associate** vs **connect**

connect

is very broad and can describe physical, technical, logical, or abstract links.

associate

often emphasizes:

- * mental linkage;
- * perceived relationship;
- * social/professional connection.

> “I associate this song with summer.”

natural.

> “I connect this song with summer.”

possible, but less idiomatic in this personal-memory sense.

Important distinction: **associate vs relate**

relate A to B

often means show or understand how two things are connected.

associate A with B

often means mentally or conceptually link them.

> “People associate red with danger.”

= 人們會把紅色和危險聯想到一起。

> “The report relates income to spending.”

= 報告說明收入與支出的關係。

There is overlap, but their usual collocations differ.

Important distinction: **associate with vs be friends with**

associate with someone

= have social contact with someone

be friends with someone

= have a friendship relationship

You can **associate with** someone without being close friends.

So **associate with** is broader and more formal.

Important distinction: **associate vs colleague**

associate

can mean a professional contact, colleague, or business partner.

colleague

specifically means someone you work with in the same organization or profession.

So:

> business associate

does not necessarily mean:

> colleague

The person may work for another company.

Important distinction: **association vs relationship**

association

often means a connection or link between things.

relationship

is broader and may involve:

- * personal relationships;
- * causal/structural relationships;
- * long-term interactions.

> association between two variables

often means they occur together or are statistically linked, not necessarily that one causes the other.

Important caution: **association does not automatically mean causation**

In academic and scientific contexts:

> two things are associated

means they are linked or occur together in some way.

It does **not** automatically mean**:**

> one causes the other.

This is a useful distinction for learners because **associated with** is extremely common in academic English.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

- * **associate**
- * **associated**
- * **associating**
- * **association**
- * **associative**

Useful constructions include:

- * associate A with B
- * be associated with
- * associate with someone
- * business associate
- * research associate
- * associate member
- * professional association

The Golden Manual says a family sweep should include derivations, compounds, grammatical patterns, and specialist uses, but closely related contexts should still be merged when one core semantic idea explains them.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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associate A with B — mental/conceptual link	在思想中把兩個人、事物、概念或經歷聯繫起來，使其中一個令人想到另一個
be associated with — related/connected	與某人、事物、情況、機構或結果存在關聯
associate with someone — social contact	與某人來往、交往或保持社交接觸

associate — noun	與某人有工作、商業或專業關係的同事、夥伴或同業人
士	
associate + title/status	某些機構中的副級、初級、中階或準會員性質職位；具體
含義依機構而定	
association — connection	兩個人、事物、概念或經歷之間的心理或實際聯繫
association — organization	因共同職業、興趣、目的或身分組成的正式協會 / 團體
體	
associative	與聯想或事物之間的連結思維有關的

For your original sentence

> “...I still ****associate him with**** some of the happiest and simplest years of my life.”

The exact meaning is:

****associate A with B = 在記憶 / 思想中把 A 和 B 聯繫起來，使 A 自然令人想到 B****

So:

> ****associate him with my happiest childhood years****

= ****把他和我最快樂的童年歲月聯想在一起****

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****associate****:

1. ****verb — mentally or conceptually connect A with B****
2. ****verb — associate with someone socially / have contact with****
3. ****noun — professional or business colleague/partner****
4. ****associate + title/status — a formal rank or secondary/member-level role****

I would merge ****be associated with something**** into #1 as a broader connection use, and keep ****association**** and ****associative**** as family extensions rather than inflate the base-word count.